

SEWV Support Knowledge Base — 00: Overview & Workflow

Source: Ailsa's VA training tutorials (Google Drive), compiled July 2026. This knowledge base supports drafting replies to Speak English With Vanessa (SEWV) customer emails.

The business

Speak English With Vanessa (SEWV) sells English-fluency courses (the "Fearless Fluency Club" and related challenges) via Teachable, with email marketing/automation on Kit, and payments through Stripe (primary) and PayPal (secondary).

Team & roles

- **Vanessa** — owner/instructor. Final say on judgment calls, non-standard discounts, and anything unusual (over ~6-12 months old refund requests, ambiguous collab offers, etc.)
- **Ailsa** — senior VA / trainer. Author of most of these tutorials. Has her own Gmail label/folder.
- **Amber** — English-content teacher. Handles grammar/pronunciation-specific student questions.
- **Norah** — VA in training; being onboarded onto this material. In the video tutorials, Ailsa addresses Norah directly as "you."

Team members communicate by emailing/tagging each other directly, or by creating an email draft and tagging the intended reader using the Gmail label system. Always start "Hi [Name]" and sign your own name so it's clear who a message is to/from.

The general/main inbox and spam folder

The **general inbox** (no label applied) is mostly "random" emails — people who typed Vanessa's email address directly, or replies via the website contact form. Other things occasionally end up there too, and that's fine/expected — it's not meant to be a strictly filtered view. **Spam folder:** checked only occasionally (not routinely) for anything important that got misclassified — this is rare but does happen. **Monthly task:** after checking, empty the spam folder. **Other Gmail system tabs** (Updates, Promotions, etc.): these already have their own labels/filters routing them elsewhere — no need to check them separately.

Inbox goals

- Goal: **empty the inbox every day**, respond to emails within **24 hours**.

- Lower-priority emails can wait a couple of days if needed to make room for higher-priority ones.
- Delete an email after responding, unless you're keeping it in a personal reference folder.
- Busiest periods: last week/first few days of each month, and any promo or challenge launch window.

Priority system

High priority (respond within 1–2 days):

- Current students / paying customers
- People likely to become paying customers (real interest, real questions)
- Payment issues, signup errors, broken links/website errors
- Anyone tagged to you by a teammate

Low priority (2–3+ days is fine):

- People unlikely to ever become paying customers who are just asking general questions
- Threads that need a reply but aren't urgent

Safe to delete without a reply — this is the majority of the inbox:

- Pure "thank you" / one-word acknowledgments, "I like your lessons," other non-personalized praise or empty messages
- Short "I can't pay" / "I have no money" messages — **delete these by default**, do not reply
- Messages with literally no ask and no personalization
- Spam-folder items that aren't real inquiries
- Threads already resolved elsewhere

Exception: if a "can't pay" message is a **long, heartfelt** explanation of the person's situation (not just a one-liner), it's worth a warm, personal reply instead of deleting — see the financial-hardship entry in [01-email-response-playbook.md](#) (needs updating to match this).

See [01-email-response-playbook.md](#) for how to handle every specific email type, and [02-admin-task-procedures.md](#) for the exact backend (Teachable/Kit/Stripe/PayPal) steps a human admin needs to do after certain replies.

Standard email format

Links: insert links as hyperlinked text (e.g. "click here to join" or "here's the link"), not as a raw pasted URL. This applies to every draft, not just specific templates.

Hi [Name],

Thanks for your email. I'm so glad that you are learning English with me!

[Answer / body content]

I hope that helps. Keep up the good work with English!

Vanessa

English Teacher

[Website]

Notes:

- If you're mid-thread with someone (already exchanged several emails), you don't need to repeat "Thanks for your email, I'm so glad you're learning English with me" every time — a shorter "Thanks for your email" is fine.
- Prefer plain, simple wording ("can" instead of "are able to") since most recipients are English learners.
- Capitalize course names as proper nouns: "the Fearless Fluency Club," "the Monthly Membership."
- One sentence per line reads better for ESL readers in promotional/marketing copy (see [05-promo-email-style-notes.md](#)); standard support replies can stay in normal paragraph form.

Names & contact-form quirks

- Website contact-form submissions do NOT validate the email address — people frequently mistype it. This is never the VA's fault; just do your best guess (e.g., "gamil" → "gmail").
- Many cultures order names family-name-first (common in Vietnam, Japan, and elsewhere). If unsure, a quick web search of "[name] given name [country]" usually clarifies it. If you can't figure it out in reasonable time, "Hi there," is an acceptable greeting.
- Contact-form replies route through contact@speakeenglishwithvanessa.com rather than the sender directly — this is expected, not an error.

Tagging teammates in the shared inbox

If an email isn't yours to handle, apply the relevant teammate's label (e.g., "V" for Vanessa) and remove the "Inbox" label so it only lives in their folder — this keeps the shared inbox from feeling cluttered/duplicated.

This knowledge base is the authoritative source

Files 00–06 have been through extensive review and correction and represent the current, accurate state of the business — treat them as authoritative over any older tutorial video, transcript, or FAQ doc in Drive, even where those disagree. **If a situation comes up that isn't covered anywhere in this knowledge base, tag Vanessa** rather than falling back on an older/uncorrected source, so it can get added here properly.

Drafting priority order

When drafting a reply: **check 06-phrase-express-exact-templates.md first** — these are the team's actual proven wording, and should be used as close to verbatim as possible (customize only the bracketed/underlined parts for the specific student). If there's no matching template there, check **05-voice-guide-and-additional-scenarios.md** for tone/scenario guidance, then **01-email-response-playbook.md** for the broader policy on how to handle the situation. **Always defer to 01/03 for anything price- or product-specific**, even when a file 06 template shows an old number — the wording pattern is still good, just swap in the current figure.

Templates are modular, not all-or-nothing. Some templates (e.g. the Zoom/Fearless Fluency Chats one) bundle a lot of information together for genuinely broad questions. If a student asks something narrow ("what's the link to join the weekly lesson?"), send just the relevant part — not the whole block. Match the length and content of the reply to what was actually asked.

Watch for templates that assume unverifiable context. Some older templates reference things like "click the link in the email above" — assuming a specific link exists in whatever the student is replying to, which isn't something Claude can confirm without a Teachable/Kit connection. When a template depends on the specific email thread's content, the student's enrollment status, or other account-specific facts Claude can't currently verify, **flag it for a human instead of auto-drafting it** — route to the high-priority/Admin Actions Needed folder rather than guessing.

Phrase Express — resolved

Ailsa's Phrase Express canned-response library has been incorporated as **05-voice-guide-and-additional-scenarios.md** (voice patterns + scenarios not

otherwise covered) and [06-phrase-express-exact-templates.md](#) (the verbatim/near-verbatim templates themselves) — added July 27, 2026.